

Parliamentary Procedure

How to Run a Meeting in Five Steps

Parliamentary procedure is a shared set of rules that lets a group make decisions fairly. It keeps one loud voice from running the room, it gives quieter Scouts a guaranteed chance to speak, and it ends every decision with a clear result that the whole group witnessed.

Running a meeting comes down to **five steps**. Larger organizations use more detailed rules for complicated situations, but those rules are built on top of these same five steps. Learn them and you can lead a patrol or a troop through any decision it needs to make.



The Chairperson runs the meeting — not the argument.

The Scout in the chair has one job: guide the group through the five steps and give every member a fair chance to be heard. A Chairperson who does that has run a good meeting, no matter which way the vote goes.

SECTION 1

How a Motion Moves Through a Meeting

Every decision a group makes travels the same path, in the same order, every time.

1 A Motion

A motion is a formal proposal. It turns a loose conversation into one specific question the group can answer. The Chairperson opens the business by asking:

CHAIRPERSON

“Is there a motion?”

Any member may make one, and a motion always begins with the words *“I move that...”* — for example, *“I move that our next troop fundraiser be a pancake breakfast.”* Once a motion is on the floor, everyone knows exactly what is being decided. If a group has been handed a suggested opening motion and nobody volunteers, the Chairperson may ask a member to read it aloud to get things started.

2 A Second

ANY MEMBER

“I second the motion.”

A second does **not** mean that Scout agrees with the motion. It means only that they think the idea is worth the group’s time to discuss. One person’s idea should not occupy the whole group unless at least one other person wants to talk about it. If no one seconds, the motion dies and the group moves on.

3 Discussion

CHAIRPERSON

“The motion has been made and seconded. Is there any discussion?”

Now every member has a chance to speak. One Scout may think a pancake breakfast is a great idea. Another may argue that a spaghetti dinner would raise more money. A third may want to change the motion. The Chairperson’s job during discussion is to:

- Let one person speak at a time.
- Keep the discussion on the topic.
- Make sure everyone who wants to speak gets a chance.

The Chairperson is not there to win the argument. The Chairperson is there to run a fair meeting.

4 The Vote

When everyone has had a chance to speak, the Chairperson closes discussion and **restates the motion**, so that nobody votes on something they have lost track of.

CHAIRPERSON
"The motion before us is that our next troop fundraiser be a pancake breakfast. All those in favor, say aye." ... "All those opposed, say no."

Members vote by voice, or by raised hand when the Chairperson needs an exact count. A motion passes when more than half of those voting are in favor.

5 Announce the Result

A vote is not final until the Chairperson says so out loud: *"The motion passes."* or *"The motion fails."* Announcing the result leaves no doubt about what the group decided. The Chairperson then moves to the next item of business, or closes the meeting: *"This meeting is adjourned."*

ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

What It Sounds Like

One motion, start to finish. The numbers on the right mark which step the meeting is on.

CHAIR	"This meeting will come to order. The topic before us is choosing the troop's next fundraiser. Is there a motion?"	1
ALEX	"I move that our next troop fundraiser be a pancake breakfast."	1
CHAIR	"Thank you. Is there a second?"	2
JORDAN	"I second the motion."	2
CHAIR	"The motion has been made and seconded. Is there any discussion?"	3
SAM	"A pancake breakfast is easy to run, and we already know how to cook one."	3
RILEY	"I think a spaghetti dinner would raise more money—"	3
CHAIR	"One at a time, please. Riley has the floor. ... Thank you, Riley. Does anyone who has not spoken want to add anything?"	3
CHAIR	"Is there any further discussion? ... The motion before us is that our next troop fundraiser be a pancake breakfast. All those in favor, say aye."	4
MEMBERS	"Aye."	4
CHAIR	"All those opposed, say no."	4
CHAIR	"The motion passes, nine in favor and three opposed. Our next fundraiser will be a pancake breakfast. The next item of business is choosing a date."	5

What the Chairperson Says

Read the bold words out loud. Fill the blanks with your group's topic and motion.

- ① OPEN THE MEETING & CALL FOR A MOTION
"This meeting will come to order. The topic before us is _____ . Is there a motion?"

A member responds: "I move that ..."

- ② CALL FOR A SECOND
"Thank you. Is there a second?"

Another member responds: "I second the motion." If no one does, see If nobody seconds the motion in Section 3.

- ③ OPEN DISCUSSION
"The motion has been made and seconded. Is there any discussion?"

One at a time · stay on the topic · everyone who wants to speak, speaks. Call on Scouts by name: "_____, you have the floor."

- ④ CLOSE DISCUSSION, RESTATE THE MOTION, AND VOTE
"Is there any further discussion? ... The motion before us is _____ . All those in favor, say aye. ... All those opposed, say no."

- ⑤ ANNOUNCE THE RESULT
"The motion *passes / fails* — _____ in favor, _____ opposed."

Then either move to the next topic — "The next item of business is _____" — or close: "This meeting is adjourned."

Practice tip

Read this card out loud once or twice before the meeting. Knowing the five opening lines by heart is most of the job — the rest is listening and keeping order.

SECTION 2

The Chairperson’s Three Rules

Everything a Chairperson does comes back to these.

- 1 One at a time**

Only the Scout who has the floor speaks. Everyone else waits their turn, including the Chairperson.
- 2 Stay on the topic**

Discussion sticks to the motion in front of the group. Other good ideas wait for their own motion.
- 3 Everyone gets a chance**

Before calling for a vote, look around and ask whether anyone who has not spoken would like to.

SECTION 3

When Something Unexpected Happens

Four situations that come up in almost every meeting.

- If nobody seconds the motion**

Say: “**Hearing no second, the motion dies.**” Then ask whether anyone would like to make a different motion, or move to the next topic.
- If two Scouts start talking at once**

Say: “**One at a time, please. _____, you have the floor.**” Then call on the other Scout next, so nobody loses their turn.
- If someone wants to change the motion**

They say: “**I move to amend the motion to _____.**” An amendment needs its own second, its own short discussion, and its own vote. If the amendment passes, the group then votes on the motion as amended.
- If the vote is a tie**

A tie means the motion **fails**, because it did not get more than half the votes. The Chairperson normally stays out of the voting, but may vote to break a tie.

SECTION 4

Being a Good Member

A meeting only works if the Scouts who are not in the chair do their part too.

- Wait to be recognized**

Raise your hand and let the Chairperson call on you before you speak.
- Speak to the motion**

Argue about the idea in front of the group, never about the Scout who proposed it.
- Keep it short**

Make your point once and clearly, so there is time for everyone else.
- Back the decision**

Once the vote is announced, it is the group’s decision — even if you voted no.

Words You Will Hear

- Motion** — a formal proposal, always beginning “I move that...”

Amend — to change the wording of a motion before voting on it.

Aye / No — the words members say when voting by voice.
- Second** — one other member saying the motion is worth discussing.

Majority — more than half of those voting. What a motion needs to pass.

The chair — another name for the Chairperson running the meeting.
- The floor** — permission to speak. Only one Scout has it at a time.

Adjourn — to formally end the meeting.

Dies — what happens to a motion that never gets a second.

SECTION 5

How the Practice Round Works

Each group receives a discussion topic and a suggested opening motion, chooses who fills each role, and then runs the topic through all five steps. Groups may run more than one round so that different Scouts get a turn in the chair.

Chairperson Runs the five steps and keeps order.	Motion Maker Makes the opening motion when the chair asks.	Seconders Seconds the motion so discussion can begin.	Members Everyone else — discuss, amend, and vote.
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Sample Topics and Opening Motions

DISCUSSION TOPIC	SUGGESTED OPENING MOTION
Choose the troop’s next fundraiser	“I move that our next troop fundraiser be a pancake breakfast.”
Choose a destination for the spring campout	“I move that our spring campout be held at _____ State Park.”
Choose a service project for the troop	“I move that the troop hold a park cleanup this fall.”
Set a theme for the next troop meeting	“I move that the theme of our next troop meeting be first aid.”
Decide how to spend \$200 from the troop treasury	“I move that the troop spend \$200 on new patrol cooking gear.”

Check Your Meeting

- ☐ All five steps happened, in order.
- ☐ Only one Scout spoke at a time.
- ☐ The motion was restated before the vote.
- ☐ The motion was clearly stated before discussion.
- ☐ Everyone who wanted to speak got a chance.
- ☐ The Chairperson announced the result out loud.

Remember what you are practicing.

The goal is not to pick the best fundraiser or the best campout. The goal is to practice running a meeting. If the Chairperson can guide the group through all five steps while giving everyone a fair chance to participate, the group has done exactly what the requirement asks.